
NEXFLOW

The Never Miss

a Deadline Audit

23 yes/no questions that show exactly where your engineering team's delivery is breaking down — and what to fix first.

For Engineering Managers, CTOs, and VPs of Engineering

HOW TO USE THIS AUDIT

Go through all 23 questions. Answer YES or NO for your team right now — not how you want things to be, how they actually are. Tally your YES answers at the end and check your score.

Time to complete: under 10 minutes.

01 QUICK DIAGNOSTIC — ANSWER THESE FIRST

If you answer NO to 3 or more of these 5 questions, your team has a delivery problem right now.

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
1	☐	Can you name right now which tickets are at risk of missing this sprint? If you can't answer in 30 seconds, risk is invisible until it's too late.	YES	NO
2	☐	Does your team surface blockers within 24 hours of hitting them? Silent blockers are the #1 cause of late sprints.	YES	NO
3	☐	Does leadership learn about delivery risks before they become fires? Surprises mean there's no system — just hope.	YES	NO
4	☐		YES	NO

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
		Were your last 3 sprint estimates accurate within 20%?		
		Consistent misses signal a broken planning process, not bad luck.		
5	☐	Do you know today which engineer is overloaded or falling behind?	YES	NO
		You can't fix what you can't see.		

02 THE FULL 23-POINT AUDIT

— Bucket 1: Planning (Questions 6–13)

Most missed deadlines are decided in planning, not execution. Check whether your team's foundation is solid.

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
6	☐	Are sprint deadlines set based on actual team capacity, not gut feel?	YES	NO
		Optimistic planning guarantees late delivery.		
7	☐	Do ticket estimates include review time, QA, and handoff — not just coding?	YES	NO
		Coding is rarely the bottleneck. The gaps around it are.		
8	☐	Is sprint scope locked at least 24 hours before the sprint starts?	YES	NO
		Last-minute additions destroy velocity.		
9	☐	Are dependencies between tickets explicitly mapped before work starts?	YES	NO
		Hidden dependencies cause cascading delays mid-sprint.		
10	☐	Does your team break down any ticket larger than 3 days of work?	YES	NO

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
		Big tickets hide risk. Small tickets surface it.		
11	☐	Is there a clear definition of "done" for every ticket before it's picked up? Ambiguous done criteria cause rework and scope creep.	YES	NO
12	☐	Do you track historical velocity and use it in future planning? Without data, every sprint is a guess.	YES	NO
13	☐	Are on-call, meetings, and other interrupts factored into capacity? Every hour of meetings is an hour not shipping.	YES	NO

— **Bucket 2: Execution (Questions 14–19)**

Even great plans fail in execution. These questions surface where work silently stalls.

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
14	☐	Are PRs reviewed and merged within 2 business days on average? PR lag is one of the most common invisible delays in engineering.	YES	NO
15	☐	Can you tell at a glance which tickets have been sitting untouched for 2+ days? Stale tickets signal silent blockers or unclear ownership.	YES	NO
16	☐	Does every in-progress ticket have a single clear owner? Shared ownership means no ownership.	YES	NO
17	☐		YES	NO

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
		Is mid-sprint scope creep tracked and flagged — not silently absorbed?		
		Scope creep is the polite way to say missed deadline.		
18	☐	Do engineers raise concerns about timeline before it's too late to act?	YES	NO
		If problems surface on demo day, the process failed weeks earlier.		
19	☐	Are recurring blockers logged and reviewed after each sprint?	YES	NO
		Fixing the same blocker twice means the system isn't learning.		

— **Bucket 3: Communication (Questions 20–23)**

Most delivery failures are communication failures in disguise. Four questions that cut to the core.

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
20	☐	Is there a consistent format for communicating delivery status to stakeholders?	YES	NO
		Ad hoc updates create anxiety. Consistent ones build trust.		
21	☐	Do PMs and engineering managers have the same understanding of what's shipping this sprint?	YES	NO
		Misalignment here causes the most painful deadline conversations.		
22	☐	When a deadline is at risk, is there a clear process for escalating and replanning?	YES	NO
		Teams that have no replanning process just silently slip.		
23	☐		YES	NO

#	✓	QUESTION	YES	NO
		After a missed deadline, does the team run a structured retro to fix the root cause? Post-mortems prevent the next miss. Skipping them guarantees it.		

03 YOUR SCORE + WHAT IT MEANS

Count your YES answers. **My score:** _____ / 23

20–23	Delivery Machine	Your process is solid. Focus on optimization and scale.
14–19	Some Cracks	You have a working system but recurring gaps. Fix the NO answers first.
7–13	At Risk	Deadlines are being missed or will be soon. Prioritize the Planning bucket.
0–6	On Fire	Systemic delivery breakdown. You need a new process, not a patch.

WHAT TO DO WITH YOUR RESULTS

Start with your NO answers in the Planning bucket — planning failures cause the most downstream damage.

Then fix Execution, then Communication. In that order.

The hard part isn't knowing what's broken. It's catching it 2–3 weeks before a deadline slips — when you can still act on it.

Want to see this automatically — before deadlines slip?

NexFlow flags delivery risks 2–3 weeks in advance by connecting to your existing tools — GitHub, Linear, Slack, and Google Calendar. No new process. Just early warnings.

Book a 20-minute call → calendly.com/arjundixit3508/30min

Or reach out directly: arjundixit@nexflowinc.com

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